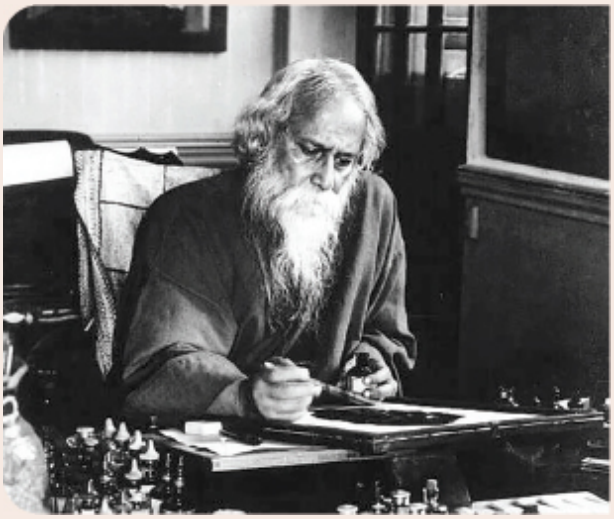


Literature flourished in many parts of British India but especially in Bengal. Rabindranath Tagore (1861-1941), India’s only winner of the Nobel Prize in Literature, wrote in Bengali and translated his works into English.

From older works like the Vedas and the Tamil epics to medieval poetry, narratives and drama, literature flourished in the Indian subcontinent for thousands of years. However, a large number of Indians were denied education, which meant that access to written literature was limited. But, by the nineteenth century, more Indians had access to education (in English or otherwise), which also meant that more people were reading and writing about India.

With exposure to literature from Britain, Europe and the United States, Indians began to adopt new forms of writing to tell Indian stories. Short stories, poetry and novels in